

REWIRED FOR DOPAMINE HITS

WHY OUR KIDS' BRAINS ARE DIFFERENT



ROBLOX, MINECRAFT, AND CANDY CRUSH ARE REWIRING THE REWARD SYSTEM. HERE'S WHAT TO DO ABOUT IT.



THE SERIES

FIVE LESSONS. ONE PLAYER.

01

Why Our Kids' Brains Are Different

← You are here

02

The 12-Week Checkpoint Model

Coming up.

03

Old-School Coaching vs. Modern Athletes

Coming up.

04

From Obligation to Investment

Coming up.

05

Gamification for the Long Game

Coming up.

HEAR THIS ONCE

THE REWARD SYSTEMS BUILT INTO GAMES ARE REWIRING OUR CHILDREN'S BRAINS FOR ADDICTION AND GAMBLING. THIS IS NOT A PARENTING FAILURE. IT IS A DESIGN INTENTION.

Loot boxes, random rewards, achievement badges gamification tactics are designed to keep kids playing. The youth athletic system, as it was built, is not designed for this version of a child. The shift needs to happen here.

— GAMIFICATION CAN GO BOTH WAYS · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE GAMIFICATION MODEL

IF GAMIFICATION CAN HOOK
KIDS INTO BAD HABITS, IT CAN
ALSO HOOK THEM INTO GOOD
ONES.

- The same dopamine loop that keeps kids on screens can be redirected toward athletic development
- Checkpoints, metrics, and visible progress create the same reward signal
- The goal: make growth feel like progress, not just obligation

— THE DOPAMINE SYSTEM DOESN'T CARE WHERE THE REWARD COMES FROM. REDIRECT IT.

UNDERSTANDING THE LOOP

THE HOOK

Random reward, achievement badges, loot boxes all trigger the same dopamine response as progress in any domain.



THE PROBLEM

Youth athletics as currently designed is built for delayed gratification the wrong system for instant-gratification brains.

THE OPPORTUNITY

Apply the gamification model deliberately in athletic development.



REDIRECTING THE LOOP

IN PRACTICE

Create visible checkpoints week 1, week 6, week 12 where metrics are taken and growth is made visible.

WATCH FOR

Athletes who disengage from training when results aren't immediately visible this is the dopamine gap.

THE SHIFT

From expecting intrinsic motivation to building external structures that create visible wins.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

YOUR ATHLETE'S BRAIN IS WIRED FOR
REWARD SIGNALS. YOUR JOB IS TO
PUT THE REWARD SIGNALS IN THE
RIGHT PLACES.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

— THE REDIRECT LAW

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, CREATE ONE VISIBLE CHECKPOINT.

- ✓ Choose one measurable skill: serving percentage, passing grade, vertical jump
- ✓ Take a baseline measurement this week
- ✓ Set a six-week checkpoint date and mark it on the calendar
- ✓ Tell your athlete: 'We're tracking progress, not just practicing.'



REWIRED FOR DOPAMINE HITS

THE 12-WEEK CHECKPOINT MODEL

02

WEEK 1. WEEK 6. WEEK 12. PROGRESS THAT IS VISIBLE IS PROGRESS THAT COMPOUNDS.



THE SERIES

FIVE LESSONS. ONE PLAYER.

01

Why Our Kids' Brains Are Different

Complete.

02

The 12-Week Checkpoint Model

← You are here

03

Old-School Coaching vs. Modern Athletes

Coming up.

04

From Obligation to Investment

Coming up.

05

Gamification for the Long Game

Coming up.

HEAR THIS ONCE

MOST YOUTH ATHLETES PRACTICE
FOR MONTHS WITHOUT EVER
MEASURING WHETHER THEY ARE
IMPROVING.

Without visible progress markers, training becomes an obligation rather than a development arc. The 12-week checkpoint model changes that by making improvement something that can be seen, felt, and celebrated.

— WHAT GETS MEASURED GETS MOTIVATED · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE CHECKPOINT MODEL

WEEK 1 METRICS. WEEK 6
CHECK-IN. WEEK 12 REVIEW.
THIS IS THE ARC THAT KEEPS
ATHLETES ENGAGED.

→ Metrics aren't just for elite athletes they are for every athlete who wants to see her progress

→ The six-week checkpoint creates a midpoint reward before the full arc is complete

→ Week 12 is the celebration moment and the start of the next arc

— PROGRESS THAT IS INVISIBLE FEELS LIKE FAILURE. MAKE IT VISIBLE.

THE ARC

WEEK 1

Establish baseline: what can she do now? This is not a judgment it's a starting point.

WEEK 6

Mid-check: what's changed? Even small improvements are legitimate progress markers.

WEEK 12

Full review: the delta from week 1 to now. This is the data that rewires the reward system toward growth.



R U N N I N G T H E M O D E L

IN PRACTICE

Choose three measurable skills at the start of the season and track them across 12 weeks.

WATCH FOR

The athlete who had a breakthrough at week 6 her engagement level will tell you everything.

THE SHIFT

From practicing without direction to training with a visible arc of development.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

GIVE YOUR ATHLETE A 12-WEEK ARC
AND SHE STOPS SHOWING UP TO
PRACTICE. SHE STARTS SHOWING UP
TO PROGRESS.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

— THE ARC

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, DESIGN THE 12-WEEK ARC.

- ✓ Choose three measurable skills to track across the next 12 weeks
- ✓ Take week 1 baseline measurements together
- ✓ Set the week 6 and week 12 checkpoint dates on the calendar now
- ✓ Celebrate the act of starting that's the first dopamine reward



REWIRED FOR DOPAMINE HITS

OLD-SCHOOL COACHING VS. MODERN ATHLETES

03

THE YOUTH ATHLETIC SYSTEM WAS BUILT FOR A DIFFERENT CHILD. THE PARENT WHO UNDERSTANDS THAT HAS THE ADVANTAGE.



THE SERIES

FIVE LESSONS. ONE PLAYER.

01

Why Our Kids' Brains Are Different

Complete.

02

The 12-Week Checkpoint Model

Complete.

03

Old-School Coaching vs. Modern

← You are here

04

From Obligation to Investment

Coming up.

05

Gamification for the Long Game

Coming up.

HEAR THIS ONCE

OLD-SCHOOL COACHING ASSUMES
DELAYED GRATIFICATION, INTRINSIC
MOTIVATION, AND FEAR OF AUTHORITY.
MODERN ATHLETES OPERATE ON INSTANT
FEEDBACK, VISIBLE PROGRESS, AND
INTERNAL BUY-IN.

This is not a complaint about coaches or kids. It is an observation about a systems mismatch and the parent who understands it can bridge the gap rather than be frustrated by it.

—BRIDGE THE GAP. DON'T FIGHT THE SYSTEM. · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE BRIDGE

THE SYSTEM WILL EVOLVE. UNTIL
IT DOES, THE BRIDGE IS BUILT AT
HOME.

- Understand the system: old-school coaching is real, and it has real value don't dismiss it
- Understand your athlete: she is wired differently than coaches expect her to be
- Bridge the gap: create gamification structures at home that translate to old-school environments

— THE PARENT WHO BRIDGES THE GAP GIVES HER ATHLETE A COMPETITIVE ADVANTAGE.

THE MISMATCH

OLD SYSTEM

Hard work, delayed reward, respect for authority, intrinsic motivation assumed.



MODERN ATHLETE

Visible progress, immediate feedback loop, buy-in required before full effort, instant gratification wired in.

THE BRIDGE

Create structures at home that honor both intrinsic values with gamification mechanics.



BUILDING THE BRIDGE

IN PRACTICE

Before the next practice, ask: 'What are you working on today that will show up in your checkpoint?'

WATCH FOR

Whether she has a connection between today's practice and her 12-week arc.

THE SHIFT

From going to practice to going to build a specific piece of the arc.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

YOU CAN'T CHANGE THE SYSTEM
ALONE. BUT YOU CAN BRIDGE THE
GAP FOR YOUR ATHLETE AND THAT
MAKES ALL THE DIFFERENCE.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

— THE BRIDGE LAW

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, CONNECT PRACTICE TO THE ARC.

✓ Before practice: 'What are you working on today that counts toward your checkpoint?'

✓ After practice: 'Did you get that work in? What happened?'

✓ If there's a disconnect, problem-solve together don't criticize the coach

✓ Track connection between daily practice and the 12-week arc over four weeks



REWIRED FOR DOPAMINE HITS

FROM OBLIGATION TO INVESTMENT



WHEN ATHLETES SEE PROGRESS, THEY STOP BEING PARTICIPANTS AND START BEING INVESTORS.

THE SERIES

FIVE LESSONS. ONE PLAYER.

01

Why Our Kids' Brains Are Different

Complete.

02

The 12-Week Checkpoint Model

Complete.

03

Old-School Coaching vs. Modern Athletes

Complete.

04

From Obligation to Investment

← You are here

05

Gamification for the Long Game

Coming up.

HEAR THIS ONCE

**An athlete who is obligated to practice will give you the minimum.
An athlete who is invested in her development will surprise you.**

The shift from obligation to investment does not happen through lectures. It happens when athletes can see, feel, and celebrate their own progress. That's not a soft concept — it's neuroscience.

— LAW 4 · INVESTMENT REQUIRES VISIBILITY · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE INVESTMENT MODEL

AN ATHLETE WHO SEES HER OWN PROGRESS DOESN'T NEED TO BE MOTIVATED. SHE IS ALREADY IN MOTION.

→ Obligation: 'I have to go to practice.'

→ Investment: 'I want to see what week 6 looks like.'

→ The difference is made by the visibility of progress — and your role in creating it

— MOTIVATION IS A BYPRODUCT OF VISIBLE PROGRESS.

THE MOTIVATION MYTH

THE MYTH

Some kids are motivated and some aren't. The motivated ones will succeed.

THE REALITY

Motivation is manufactured by structure, visibility, and celebrated progress.

THE TOOL

The checkpoint model is a motivation manufacturing system when it is used consistently.

01



06 · THE APPLICATION

MANUFACTURING MOTIVATION

IN PRACTICE

At week 6, celebrate the data whether it went up or not. The practice of measurement is the win.

WATCH FOR

The first time she comes home and reports her own progress unprompted that's investment.

THE SHIFT

From you tracking her progress to her tracking it herself and reporting back.

02



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS · COME BACK TO IT

YOU DON'T NEED TO MANUFACTURE
MOTIVATION. YOU NEED TO
MANUFACTURE VISIBILITY.
MOTIVATION FOLLOWS.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

— THE INVESTMENT LAW

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, CELEBRATE ONE SMALL PROGRESS WIN.

✓ Identify one small improvement from this week versus last week

✓ Name it explicitly: 'Last week you did X. This week you did Y. That's progress.'

✓ Let her feel the win don't immediately move to the next goal

✓ Notice her energy for the next practice after a celebrated win



REWIRED FOR DOPAMINE HITS

GAMIFICATION FOR THE LONG GAME

OS

THE SEASON IS 12 WEEKS. THE CAREER IS A DECADE. BUILD THE ARC ACCORDINGLY.

THE SERIES

FIVE LESSONS. ONE PLAYER.

01

Why Our Kids' Brains Are Different

Complete.

02

The 12-Week Checkpoint Model

Complete.

03

Old-School Coaching vs. Modern Athlete

Complete.

04

From Obligation to Investment

Complete.

05

Gamification for the Long Game

← You are here

HEAR THIS ONCE

TOO MANY ATHLETES ARE
OPTIMIZED FOR THE NEXT
TOURNAMENT AND BURNED OUT BY
THE END OF THE SEASON.

The dopamine system is powerful and it needs to be pointed at a long arc, not just the next spike. Athletes who are taught to build toward a season, a year, a career develop the reward system that sustains them through the hard parts.

— THE LONGEST ARC WINS · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE LONG ARC

One season is a chapter. Train the reward system for the whole book.

→ Short arc: win this tournament. Long arc: become this athlete by the end of this year.

→ The checkpoint model can be season-level, year-level, and career-level

→ Athletes with a long arc are harder to discourage — they know where they're going

— THE ATHLETE WITH THE LONGEST ARC IS THE HARDEST TO QUIT ON.

ARC LEVELS

SEASON ARC

12-week checkpoint what does she want to have built by the end of this season?

YEAR ARC

Where does she want her game to be by this time next year?

CAREER ARC

What does the peak of her volleyball look like — and what habits are building toward it now?



BUILDING THE LONG ARC

IN PRACTICE

Ask: 'What does your game look like at the end of this season? At the end of high school?'

WATCH FOR

Whether her answers are outcome-based (make varsity) or growth-based (develop my read on defense).

THE SHIFT

From tournament-to-tournament thinking to season-and-career thinking — that's the long game.

02

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

The athlete who knows where she is going does not get lost in the moment. Build the arc. Run it.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.



THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, BUILD ONE LEVEL OF THE LONG ARC.

✓ Ask your athlete: 'What does your game look like at the end of this season?'

✓ Write down her answer in her words, not yours

✓ Connect her current 12-week checkpoint to that season-end vision

✓ Review and update the arc quarterly it's allowed to evolve

